

AFENET GrantsHub

Discovery Workbook User Guide

Practical instructions for planning, conducting, documenting and validating the Step 2 discovery exercise

Document purpose	Guide responsible persons and discovery participants in completing the AFENET GrantsHub Discovery Workbook.
Primary audience	Product owner, discovery coordinator, process owners, interviewers, validators and steering team.
Recommended duration	Six weeks, followed by consolidation and approval of the MVP requirements.
Workbook covered	AFENET_GrantsHub_Step2_Discovery_Tracker.xlsx

Expected result: A validated description of AFENET's current grants lifecycle, supported by evidence and translated into agreed requirements for GrantsHub.

Prepared for internal AFENET discovery and planning

1. Purpose of the workbook

The Discovery Workbook coordinates the structured review of how AFENET currently identifies, develops, approves, implements, monitors and closes grants. It is designed to ensure that GrantsHub is based on validated operating needs rather than assumptions.

- Assign accountability for each of the 11 discovery areas.
- Schedule interviews, workshops and document reviews.
- Capture current practices, systems, documents, controls and pain points.
- Define the desired future process and platform requirements.
- Record validation and formal sign-off.

2. Workbook structure

Worksheet	Purpose	Primary user
Start Here	Provides instructions, completion standards, participant suggestions and a live management summary.	All users; especially the product owner and steering team
Discovery Tracker	Assigns ownership, schedules each process review and tracks status, progress, sign-off and blockers.	Discovery coordinator and accountable process owners
Interview Capture	Records detailed answers, evidence, risks, desired practices and requirements for every process area.	Interviewers, workshop facilitators and subject-matter experts
Reference Lists	Explains the dropdown choices and suggests functions, methods and regional coverage.	All users needing clarification

3. Roles and responsibilities

Role	Main responsibility	Typical activities
Executive sponsor	Provides authority and resolves cross-functional barriers.	Confirms scope, receives escalations and approves final outputs.
Product owner	Owens the GrantsHub business requirements.	Prioritises needs, decides scope and accepts discovery outputs.
Discovery coordinator	Administers the workbook and six-week schedule.	Assigns owners, schedules sessions, follows up and maintains the summary.
Accountable process owner	Ensures the assigned process is accurately documented.	Names contributors, provides evidence, validates findings and signs off.
Interviewer/facilitator	Conducts structured interviews or workshops.	Records complete and neutral responses in Interview Capture.
Contributor/respondent	Explains operational practice and supplies evidence.	Describes current work, exceptions, controls, pain points and needs.
Validator	Checks that findings are accurate and sufficiently evidenced.	Reviews records, resolves gaps and confirms completion.

4. Before starting the discovery

- 1. Appoint the core team.** Confirm the executive sponsor, product owner and discovery coordinator.
- 2. Select representative cases.** Use at least one active proposal, one active multi-country award, one recently closed grant, one procurement case and one contractor payment case.
- 3. Choose participating offices.** Include the Secretariat, relevant regional hubs and at least two country programmes. Ensure Anglophone, Francophone and Lusophone perspectives are represented where practical.
- 4. Create an evidence location.** Set up a controlled shared folder for templates, screenshots, process maps and sample records. Store links in the workbook instead of embedding confidential material.
- 5. Confirm confidentiality rules.** Remove personal, banking, medical or commercially sensitive information from examples unless access is specifically authorised.
- 6. Agree the calendar.** Set a six-week schedule with time reserved for interviews, follow-up, validation and steering-team review.

Important: The workbook is a discovery control tool, not the permanent repository for sensitive grant, contract or payment documents.

5. How to use the Start Here worksheet

The Start Here sheet is the orientation and management-summary page. Its figures update from the Discovery Tracker.

- Review the purpose statement and completion standard with every participant.
- Use the summary cards to monitor completed, in-progress, not-started and overdue areas.
- Confirm that the proposed participants reflect AFENET's departments, four regional hubs and selected country programmes.
- Do not type over the summary formulas. Update status and dates in Discovery Tracker instead.

6. How to use the Discovery Tracker

The Discovery Tracker contains one row for each lifecycle process. The discovery coordinator maintains it, while accountable process owners supply and validate the information.

Field group	What to enter	Good practice
Ownership	Named accountable person and sign-off person.	Use a person's full name and role; do not leave accountability only at department level.
Participation	Required contributors and offices/programmes to consult.	Include people who perform the work, approve it and depend on its output.
Method	Interview, workshop, walkthrough, focus group or document review.	Use workshops for cross-functional decisions and walkthroughs for system-heavy processes.

Field group	What to enter	Good practice
Evidence	Templates, trackers, agreements, screenshots, policies or record links.	Use representative samples and record the location, owner and date.
Schedule	Planned start, actual start and due date.	Use real Excel dates in YYYY-MM-DD format.
Progress	Status, priority and percentage complete.	Keep status and percentage consistent; 100% should normally mean Completed.
Closure	Sign-off person, sign-off date and unresolved blockers.	Do not close an area while material evidence or decisions remain outstanding.

Status definitions

Status	Use when
Not Started	No interview, workshop or evidence review has begun.
Scheduled	Participants and a session date have been confirmed.
In Progress	Discovery work has begun and evidence is being collected.
Awaiting Validation	Initial findings are complete and awaiting owner review or sign-off.
Completed	All completion criteria are met and sign-off is recorded.
On Hold	Work cannot proceed because of a documented dependency or decision.

7. How to use the Interview Capture worksheet

Interview Capture contains a standard set of questions for each discovery area. Complete one row for each question. Add rows when practices differ by donor, project, department, hub or country programme.

Question category	What the facilitator should establish
People	Who initiates, performs, reviews, approves and owns the result?
Workflow	What happens from initiation to completion, including hand-offs and decisions?
Approvals	What authority, thresholds and evidence of approval are required?
Information	What data is captured, by whom, and which fields are mandatory?
Documents	What templates, forms and supporting records are created or received?
Systems	Which spreadsheets, email accounts, drives, portals or systems are used?
Timing	How long does each stage take and where do delays occur?
Variations	How does the process differ by donor, country, hub, language, project type or value?
Controls	What compliance checks, audit evidence and segregation of duties apply?
Pain points	Where do duplication, errors, weak visibility or manual work occur?
Future state	What should GrantsHub automate, integrate, report, notify or prevent?
Measures	How will AFENET know that the redesigned process is working?

Recording a strong response

- State the actual current practice, not only the official policy.
- Name the role responsible for each step and approval.
- Record systems and documents by their recognised names.
- Separate facts, pain points and proposed solutions into their respective columns.
- Describe variations explicitly instead of averaging them into one generic process.
- Translate each material gap into a requirement or decision.
- Assign a priority and follow-up date for unresolved issues.

Example: Current practice: country teams email proposal budgets to Finance in different formats. Pain point: consolidation and version control are slow. Future practice: one controlled budget template with submission status and version history. Requirement: GrantsHub must maintain a single approved proposal-budget version and record Finance approval.

8. Conducting interviews and workshops

- 1. Prepare.** Review existing evidence, identify the respondent's role and select the relevant discovery questions.
- 2. Open the session.** Explain the purpose, scope, confidentiality expectations and how findings will be validated.

3. **Walk through a real case.** Ask the respondent to demonstrate a recently completed or active example from beginning to end.
4. **Probe exceptions.** Ask what changes by donor, funding mechanism, country, value, urgency or language.
5. **Confirm controls.** Identify approvals, supporting evidence, access restrictions and segregation of duties.
6. **Summarise.** Read back the main workflow, risks and proposed requirements before closing.
7. **Follow up.** Send outstanding evidence and decisions to named owners with due dates.

9. Evidence management

Useful evidence may include:

- Opportunity trackers, donor notices and go/no-go records.
- Proposal templates, budgets, workplans, review checklists and submission receipts.
- Award agreements, amendments, setup checklists and donor conditions.
- Project workplans, activity reports, indicator tools, risk logs and issue registers.
- Procurement plans, solicitations, evaluations, contracts and contractor records.
- Deliverables, acceptance records, invoices and payment-status reports.
- Narrative reports, financial reports, audit records and closeout checklists.
- Screenshots or walkthrough notes for shared drives, portals and current systems.

Evidence rule: Record a link, document name, owner and date. Use redacted or sample records where possible. Never place passwords, bank details or unrestricted personal information in the workbook.

10. Validation and sign-off

A discovery area should be marked Completed only when all of the following are true:

- The current workflow is documented from initiation to completion.
- Participants, owners and approval authority are confirmed.
- Systems, templates and supporting evidence are identified.
- Pain points, risks and process variations are recorded.
- Desired future practices and GrantsHub requirements are stated.
- Outstanding decisions have owners and due dates.
- The accountable process owner has reviewed and signed off.

11. Recommended six-week schedule

Week	Main activities	Expected output
1	Kick-off; confirm scope, owners, participants, pilot cases and evidence location.	Approved discovery plan and populated ownership fields
2	Opportunity, go/no-go, proposal development, review and submission interviews.	Validated pre-award findings and evidence gaps

Week	Main activities	Expected output
3	Award setup, workplanning and implementation interviews.	Validated award and project-execution findings
4	Procurement, contracting, deliverable acceptance and payment interviews.	Validated contractor and payment findings
5	Reporting, audit, closeout, repository and system walkthroughs.	Validated reporting and records-management findings
6	Resolve gaps; validate requirements; obtain sign-off; present summary.	Completed workbook and approved discovery conclusions

12. Quality checks before submission

- Every discovery area has a named accountable person.
- Dates are valid Excel dates and overdue items have an explanation.
- Status, percentage complete and sign-off information are consistent.
- Every material statement has evidence or is clearly identified as an assumption.
- Country, hub, donor and language variations are captured where they affect requirements.
- Requirements describe a business need and do not prematurely prescribe a technology.
- No confidential or sensitive information is exposed through unrestricted links.
- The product owner and steering team can trace each priority requirement back to discovery evidence.

13. Common mistakes to avoid

Avoid	Use instead
Listing only departments as owners.	Name the accountable person and their role.
Documenting policy without testing actual practice.	Walk through a real proposal, award, contract or payment case.
Combining different country processes into one vague answer.	Add separate rows for material variations.
Recording a complaint without a requirement.	State the risk, desired future practice and required capability.
Marking work Completed before validation.	Use Awaiting Validation until owner review and sign-off.
Uploading sensitive files into the workbook.	Store controlled evidence separately and add an authorised link.

Appendix A. Quick-start checklist

1. Confirm the executive sponsor, product owner and discovery coordinator.
2. Open the Start Here sheet and brief all participants.
3. Enter named owners, offices, dates and priorities in Discovery Tracker.
4. Schedule interviews and workshops for all 11 process areas.

5. Use real cases and gather representative evidence.
6. Complete Interview Capture during or immediately after each session.
7. Record gaps, requirements, decisions, priorities and follow-up dates.
8. Validate findings with the accountable process owner.
9. Record sign-off and set the process area to Completed.
10. Present the consolidated findings to the steering team for approval.

Appendix B. Support and governance

Questions about scheduling, workbook administration or evidence follow-up should be directed to the discovery coordinator. Questions about scope, priorities or acceptance of requirements should be directed to the GrantsHub product owner. Material compliance, privacy or access concerns should be escalated to the relevant AFENET control function before information is shared.